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To the Stanford Summer Research Program Admissions Committee,
Stanford University,

I am writing to support the application of Kavish Kumar for the Stanford Summer Research Program. Kavish completed his final-year capstone project under my supervision between January and May 2025, and I am glad to speak to his abilities and work ethic from that experience.

The project addressed speech recognition for dysarthric speakers -- a problem I suggested knowing it would stretch him. Kavish got to grips with the relevant literature at a reasonable pace and settled on a wav2vec 2.0 plus bidirectional LSTM architecture, which was a sensible choice given the constraints. The execution was mostly solid: he handled dataset preparation, pre-training on LibriSpeech, and fine-tuning on TORGO without needing significant hand-holding on the engineering side. His final results -- a word error rate of 48% and character error rate of 27% on a speaker-independent evaluation -- are respectable, though with more experience he would have pushed the analysis further and been more critical of what the numbers actually tell us.

More broadly, Kavish is a student who is actively developing his research instincts. He is technically capable -- comfortable with Python, PyTorch, and standard ML workflows -- and he is consistent and diligent in his work. Where he has room to grow is in the higher-level research skills: knowing which questions are worth asking, being appropriately sceptical of results, and writing with precision. These are things that come with exposure to a strong research environment, which is part of why a programme like Stanford's would be valuable for him at this stage.

I should note that Kavish's GPA of 7.44 does not fully reflect his practical ability. His project work was stronger than his exam performance alone would suggest, and he tends to do better in hands-on, applied contexts. I would not describe him as a top-of-cohort student, but I would describe him as a genuinely motivated one who is on a clear upward trajectory and who I think would make good use of the opportunity.

I support his application. Please feel free to reach out if you would like any further details.

Yours sincerely,

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